

States **KARNATAKA**

The Winning STREAK

Yeddyurappa basks in glory after coming good on his promise of giving the largest number of MPs to the BJP

| By Stephen David |

If the Indian Political League a.k.a General Elections, was the IPL of politics, Karnataka captain B.S. Yeddyurappa, 67, could have walked off with the Most Valuable Player award. He delivered 19 seats to the Lok Sabha in the latest parliamentary polls, the highest to the BJP's Royal Challengers, but he lost the finals and that is his biggest regret. "I had promised Advaniji the highest number of seats from my state and really wished that he would have been the prime minister, and that makes me sad," says Yeddyurappa. "I am still coming to grips with the fact that we could not make it to the Centre."

Regrets aside, the BJP can take heart from his winning formula. The RSS-trained former rice mill clerk from Shimoga district—where his 36-year-old educationist son B.Y. Raghavendra defeated four-time MP and former chief minister from the Congress S. Bangarappa—proudly declares that he draws his energy from "the RSS school of discipline". In less than four weeks, he addressed nearly 260 public meetings across the state, emerging as a single-man evangelist for the party which will complete a year in power on May 31.

His biggest strength is the strong backing from his Lingayat community—the state's largest at 18 per cent—and also his attempts to draw support from other communities, including Dalits, minorities and Vokkaligas from the southern districts. Two of his closest aides like state BJP unit chief D.V. Sadananda

Gowda and the lone woman minister in his Cabinet, Shobha Karandlaje, are Vokkaligas, the same community that JD(S) honcho H.D. Deve Gowda and External Affairs Minister S.M. Krishna belong to. "Other communities also backed me, including the minorities, Dalits and the OBCs," says Yeddyurappa, uncomfortable with being projected as a Lingayat leader. The fact is that more than a dozen Karnataka chief ministers, from K.C. Reddy, the first, to Yeddyurappa now, are from the dominant Lingayat and Vokkaliga communities.

The party also firmed its grip on the coastal and the northern parts of the state, thanks to its well-oiled grassroots network. Dakshina Kannada (Mangalore) which witnessed attacks on pubs and churches by some Hindu outfits that the BJP distanced itself from, reported the highest polling percentage at nearly 75 per cent, voting the BJP to power. The party improved its vote share to nearly 42 per cent in the latest polls—up from nearly 35 per cent last year. It also won a thumbs up from urban voters, bagging all the three seats in Bangalore—Central, North and South. Bangalore Central's win for the BJP also showed that a significant number of Muslims and other minorities also cast their vote in its favour. Yeddyurappa fulfilled a pre-Assembly poll promise to induct a Muslim as a Cabinet minister and also, for the first time, threw a Christmas tea party for

HE'S KEPT THE LOTUS BLOOMING IN THE SOUTH, BUT YEDDYURAPPA MUST DELIVER THE GOODS NOW

